perhaps we are implicitly saying that we believe no such time machine will ever be built.

Actually, though, this is not a necessary conclusion. *The time machines that have thus far been proposed do not allow travel to a time prior to the construction of the first time machine itself.* For the wormhole time machine, this is easy to see by examining Figure 15.5. Although there is a time difference between the wormhole mouths, and although that difference allows travel forward and backward in time, you can't reach a time before the time difference was established. The wormhole itself does not exist on the far left of the spacetime loaf, so there is no way you can use it to get there. Thus, if the first time machine is built, say, 10,000 years from now, *that* moment will no doubt attract many time-traveling tourists, but all previous times, such as ours, will remain inaccessible.

I find it curious and compelling that our current understanding of nature's laws not only suggests how to avoid the seeming paradoxes of time travel but also offers proposals for how time travel might actually be accomplished. Don't get me wrong: I count myself among the sober physicists who feel intuitively that we will one day rule out time travel to the past. But until there's definitive proof, I think it justified and appropriate to keep an open mind. At the very least, researchers focusing on these issues are substantially deepening our understanding of space and time in extreme circumstances. At the very best, they may be taking the first critical steps toward integrating us into the spacetime superhighway. After all, every moment that goes by without our having succeeded in building a time machine is a moment that will be forever beyond our reach and the reach of all who follow.